

Go Slax, go!

I downloaded Slax 6.0.9 and made it boot up on a VMWare Workstation VM. It, as always, didn't fail to surprise me with its sub-10 second boot to KDE. But the boot threw up another surprise—a new option to start Slax as a PXE server. It turned out that this option makes Slax boot up as usual, but starts a TFTP server in the background with the Slax CD as the root. This means that if you were to start up a computer and boot from a network, Slax would boot as if the CD was inserted locally in the client's PC. Neat!

I still detest what they did to the boot splash. Slax 5 used to have a Slax flower above the scrolling boot log, but it has been done away with in version 6. I wonder why.

Slax's 'Always Fresh' feature is another neat trick. Suppose you had been saving a persistent home all along, but suddenly wanted to boot a pristine distribution, the 'Always Fresh' option will ignore the persistence file.

You don't need to download the tarball and ISO separately for the USB and CD; each will work for the other. If you downloaded the ISO, burn it to a CD or DVD and it will work fine. If you want a USB version, copy everything inside the ISO to the root of the USB drive and run `/media/disk1/boot/bootinst.sh` (assuming `/media/disk1/` is the directory where your USB stick is mounted) to make the USB stick bootable. Conversely, for the tarball, the USB installation procedure is the same, but if you need an ISO, run the script `slax/make_iso.sh` to create an ISO and burn it to a CD or DVD.

The GUI—Slacks and boots

Less than 10 seconds after I hit **ENTER** on the SYSLINUX boot menu, I was greeted by the KDE 3.5.10 splash screen and the Boots wallpaper. Nothing has really changed here; it's all the same as in the earlier version 6 desktops. One word of advice: the root password is 'toor', if you ever need it.

X defaulted to 800 x 600 in VMWare. It doesn't include ATI or NVIDIA drivers, and due to a lack of blanks, I was unable to test out native on my NVIDIA 7100 iGPU. If it doesn't work, you should be dropped to a console. Type in *guisafe* and X should start up in VESA mode.

Table 1 sums up all the software included with this version. Slackware 12.2 came as a disappointment to me—no KDE4, no Python 2.6 and no GCC 4.3, while Slax seems to have taken all the software that Slackware had. The latest KDE 3.5 stable release is included, and all the apps are Qt-based (with no space for GTK+).

The absence of Mozilla Firefox really infuriated me: Konqueror 3 is not at all a replacement for Firefox, but it still works. When it comes to the Web, I was unable to configure my ADSL (broadband) service in a bridge mode whatever I did. Looks like I have to keep

List of applications installed by default

Category	Software included
Games	KBattleship, KBounce, Patience
Graphics	KuickShow (image viewer), KColourPaint (Paint-like software), KSnapshot (screen-shot capture), KColourChooser (colour chooser)
Internet	Konqueror, KMail, Kopete, Akregator, Krdc (remote desktop), Krfb (VNC), KNetAttach (network folder browser), KPPP, network-conf, KWiFiManager
Multimedia	JuK, KPlayer, KsCD, K3B, KAudioCreator, KMix
Office	KWord, KSpread, KPresenter, Kontact, KPDF
Utilities	KJots, KWrite, KNotes, Klipper, KCalc, Ark
System	Slax Module Manager, KInfoCenter, KSysGuard
Command Line	GCC 4.2.4, BusyBox 1.11.1

Table 1



Figure 1: Default desktop

my modem in PPPoE mode. RP-PPPoE is included, but it didn't work. Two more things to whine about—no torrent client and no firewall.

As with Slax, MP3s play out of the box. WMAs don't, but that's the same as with JuK. The media player KPlayer uses MPlayer as its backend and can play anything that is thrown at it.

Under the hood

Under the hood, Slax runs on Linux 2.6.27.8, which is not the stock Slackware kernel. Since the kernel had to be re-built (patched to support LZMA and AUFS), I guess Tomáš Matějčík (the Slax developer) went with the latest kernel. All the command-line utilities are provided by BusyBox 1.11.1 (what a version!). SquashFS has been upgraded to version 3.4 and fixes a bug with the earlier UNSQUASHFS version. Slax 6 uses